THE BATTLE OF THE DOWNS

EIGHTY YEARS WAR



THE BATTLE OF THE DOWNS

Date	October 31, 1639
Location	South coast of England
Result	Dutch victory

COMBATANTS

DUTCH REPUBLIC	SPAIN

COMMANDERS

Maarten Tromp	Antonio de Oquendo

FORCES

Ships: 105 warships	**Ships:** c.40 warships, 40 transport ships

LOSSES

Men: 500 **Ships:** 1	**Men:** 700 **Ships:** 29 destroyed, 14 captured

Before the battle of the Downs
The Dutch fleet assembles off the straits of Dover. In the foreground is Tromp's flagship *Aemilia*. The coat-of-arms on the ship's stern belongs to Prince Frederick Henry of Orange-Nassau.

In 1639 Spain's long struggle to suppress the Dutch revolt was in its desperate final phase. At war with France, the Spanish could only reinforce and pay its troops in the Netherlands by sea. Antonio de Oquendo was put in command of a fleet of around 40 Spanish and Portuguese warships and a similar number of troop transports to sail from Spain to Flanders.

The Spanish fleet sailed from La Coruña on September 16. Nine days later Dutch Admiral Maarten Tromp, on board *Aemilia*, spotted them heading along the Channel toward the Catholic (i.e. pro-Spanish) port of Dunkirk. Tromp had only 13 ships, one of which he soon lost. He was joined by Witte Corneliszoon de With, vice admiral of Holland and West Frisia, with five more, but was still heavily outgunned by the Spanish, whose men-of-war were much larger as well as more numerous than the Dutch. Yet Tromp engaged his enemy in a running duel, adopting a line of battle firing broadsides. Many of Oquendo's ships took damage. Concerned above all for the safety of his transports, the Spanish commander took refuge in the Downs, an anchorage on the English coast. He expected the protection of the English, who were officially neutral but covertly pro-Spanish.

SPAIN IN ECLIPSE

Tromp established a blockade of the Downs and gathered reinforcements. The Dutch authorities increased the blockade force to over 100 ships. English vice admiral John Pennington was sent with a squadron to observe proceedings, and English merchant ships began ferrying Spanish troops and treasure to Flanders. Tromp ordered English ships to be stopped and searched. The situation was delicate, for the Dutch did not want to go to war with England but wanted to destroy the Spanish fleet. With winter drawing near, Tromp knew he could not sustain the blockade indefinitely.

On October 31, with an easterly wind in their favor, the Dutch decided to attack. Leaving one squadron to deter Pennington from intervening, Tromp sailed into the Downs. By accident or design, some of the Spanish ships ran ashore, where they were gleefully plundered by English crowds that had gathered to see the fighting. Others followed Oquendo's flagship *Santiago* in an attempted dash for



Grappling hook
A ship attempting to board an enemy would throw grappling hooks aboard, usually hoping to snag them in the rigging.